Constantinople, by forcing Bayezid to give up the siege.

He does not seem to have had designs on Byzantium itself. Instead, he was bent on re-creating the old Mongol empire. Genghis Khan and his successors had terrified the kings of Europe, but they had also established a Mongol border past which Timur was not inclined to pass. In fact, he had approached John VII in friendship once already; he had sent two ambassadors to Constantinople (one of them a Turkish Muslim, the other a Dominican priest), requesting that the emperor not make any sort of truce with Bayezid, since Timur himself was about to engage the Ottomans on the eastern flank.[6]

The Timurid army arrived in Ottoman territory in the summer of 1402 and laid siege to the castle of Ankara. By the end of July, Bayezid had arrived with his own army to drive back the invaders.

Timur's army numbered around 140,000; Bayezid's, close to 85,000. Fighting on the Timurid side were numerous Turkish chiefs who had been displaced by the spread of the Ottoman empire and wanted revenge; the Ottomans were reinforced by Serbian troops and the the Serbian vassal "king" Stefan Lazarević. Timur soon showed himself to be the better strategist, as well as the commander of the bigger army. His encampment was set up to block the Ottomans from nearby water sources, so that they went into battle thirsty. He also planned to repeat the fire attack that had worked so well in Delhi; this time, soldiers launched "Greek fire" (unquenchable streams of burning liquid, probably sulfur-based) into the enemy ranks from the backs of thirty-two specially trained elephants.[7]

Fighting began early on the morning of July 28 and continued for the entire day, but by the end of it the Ottoman troops had been driven back; Bayezid himself and two of his sons were taken captive. At once, Timur sent John of Constantinople another message: Guard the Strait of Bosphorus with Byzantine galleys, so that the defeated Ottoman troops cannot flee across it and escape.[8]

Relieved of the Turkish threat, Manuel and John were finally given the space to draw a deep breath. The Timurids raided deep into the Ottoman lands; within a matter of weeks, the Ottoman empire had shrunk back to its core domains, with Timur claiming dominion over the rest. Bayezid himself died in captivity, sometime in 1403. Of his six sons, two were in captivity, one fled to Constantinople, changed his name to Demetrius, and had himself baptized as a Christian, and the remaining three struggled to claim their father's title for themselves.

The division of the Ottoman empire lasted for twenty years. Bayezid's third son, Suleyman, managed to seize the western territories, and held on to them by freeing Manuel from his vassal status and allowing him to reclaim